



Pictured in this postcard, along with the home of a beaver, is the common reed, *Phragmites australis*. Perhaps the most visible structure in the picture is the fuzzy looking head of the plant, which is where the flowers would have at one point been. Were it not winter and these plants were in bloom, the heads would be sporting hairy seeds. These hairs help the seeds to spread, offering more wind resistance and friction should it come in contact with a vertebrate capable of transporting it. Upon arrival in an area, the plant grows a rhizome, which allows the plant to be perennial. As the rhizome is underground, it offers a higher chance of survival, and therefore establishment, because the above ground conditions make little difference. Once establishment occurs, the head of the plant produces many flowers and seeds at once, allowing for easier spread due to the large quantity of seeds.